A crocodile went shopping.

She walked into a big department store.

First, she tried some nail polish.

Black? Too weird.

Pink? Too girly.

Bright red? Yes! The colour matched her lipstick.

The moving staircase carried her up to the second floor.

Next, she tried on some hats.

A cute berry hat? Too small.

A peaked cap? Too sporty.

A flowery sunhat? Yes! It was pretty. She bought it.

Then she tried on some dresses.

A plain grey dress? Too ordinary.

A little black dress? Too evening.

A bright, sunny dress with flowers? Yes! That was her style.

Finally, she chose a handbag.

A tiny purse on a strap? Too small.

A backpack? Too school.

A big, smart, scaly handbag? Yes! That matched her complexion.

She hooked it over her arm.

Now she was the best-dressed crocodile on all of Oxford Street.

Shopping is tiring. It was time for tea.

The moving staircase carried her up to the café at the top of the store.

She sat down at a little table.

She placed her handbag on the chair beside her. And poured some tea. And ate a scone with jam and cream.

Suddenly, a hand grabbed the handbag.

The crocodile grabbed it too.

The thief tugged. And she pulled. And they both heaved.

The table rattled. The cups shook.

The café went quiet.

The manager hurried over.

“Excuse me,” he said. “You can’t have a tug of war in the café.”

The crocodile let go. And the thief ran away.

A little boy stood up.

“He stole her handbag,” he said.

The crocodile looked at the chair.

The handbag was gone.

“Oh,” she said.

She wept a crocodile tear.

“I’m so very sorry, Mrs Crocodile,” said the manager. “Would you like some cake?”

“Yes, please,” said the crocodile.

The manager brought chocolate cake with ice cream for the boy. And beetroot cake for the crocodile.

Even without her handbag, she was still the best-dressed crocodile on all of Oxford Street.

And that was the story of the Best Dressed Crocodile. And the moral of the story is that you don’t need expensive handbags to be happy. But who can live without cake?